Hillary: A Modern Greek Tragedy With a (Somewhat) Happy Ending

By Wendy Weiner

Suggested Roles: Actress 1 – Shared Chorus lines and Hillary
Actress 2 – Shared Chorus lines, Athena, Aphrodite, Bill, Newscaster

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

CHORUS: (1) Bolt the doors. / Close the curtains. / Turn off your cell phones. / For you are the few selected to finally hear the truth.

(2) In a time before Travelgate / And even Watergate, / When humans knew that it was not they - / but the gods - who ruled the earth,

(1) There was a pair even more famous than Hillary and Bill.

(2) More talked about. / More dissected. / We know - it doesn't seem possible.

(They gesture to the heavens. Lights come up on Olympus. In two separate areas stand the goddesses: Athena, strong and majestic, wearing a breastplate and holding a spear. Aphrodite, exquisitely beautiful, in golden toga and sandals. The Chorus introduces them.)

CHORUS: (1) Athena –

ATHENA: Goddess of wisdom, victory - and olives.

CHORUS: (1) And Aphrodite -

APHRODITE: The goddess of love and beauty. Obviously.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Hillary Rodham Clinton - a woman determined to succeed and achieve her dreams in a world in which the deck is stacked against her and the rules of the game thwart her at every turn.*

ACTRESS 2: *Today we call it "karma" . . . in ancient Greece, they called it "the power of the gods." Perhaps it is as author Wendy Weiner envisions it, a bit of both.*

TOGETHER: *Hillary: A Modern Greek Tragedy with a (Somewhat) Happy Ending by Wendy Weiner*

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CHORUS: (1) That's cool, you might be thinking, / But what does it have to do with ME?

(2) Let us take you then, to *our* tale, / Which does not unfold in ancient Greece / But in the United States of America.

(1) A country which espouses freedom, liberty, and happiness for all / Yet also a place where a woman has never been president

(2) In this land lived a girl who, at fourteen, / Was desperate to know all there was to know,

(1) She wrote a letter to her country's prestigious space-travel program / Asking them how to apply to become an astronaut.

(2) The letter she received back told her not to bother – girls could not apply.

(Lights come up on Hillary, at age fourteen)

HILLARY: *(Letter in hand.)* This is so unfair! . . . I'm not crying! I never cry!

CHORUS: (2) It was then that Hillary came up with her mantra. . .

HILLARY: Emotions are stupid and I am smart, Emotions are stupid and I am smart, Emotions are stupid and I am smart . . .

CHORUS: (2) Hillary walked many miles to Illinois' famed shrines / Where the altars of Athena and Aphrodite sat side by side.

(As Hillary arrives at the shrines, both goddesses go on alert to see whose shrine she'll go to. After some hesitation, Hillary goes to Athena's shrine and looks at it solemnly. She kneels in front of the altar.)

HILLARY: O, Athena, Please help me make our world a place where girls can use all the gifts given to them by the gods and become doctors and presidents and even *(Painful for her to say.)* astronauts. Help me ascend to the male seat of power, The White House. *(Sound of a lightning bolt. Hillary and Athena react.)* Get me to Washington and let me rule and I promise to protect girls and right our world's wrongs against them. *(Lights fade on Olympus as Athena descends to earth. She stands in front of Hillary, accompanied by a blaze of glorious light. Hillary is dazzled)*

ATHENA: What you want, Hillary, is not something the world wants for you. Do you understand that?

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HILLARY: That doesn't scare me.

ATHENA: It should. For deep-rooted beliefs are a far more insidious enemy than any dragon and change is far more frightening to the human spirit than a twenty-foot woman with snakes for hair.

CHORUS: (1) With her fine mind and Athena's guidance, / Hillary easily obtained entrance to Wellesley, / Where she became the first student speaker at a college graduation in the history of the country.

(2) Hillary and her speech appeared in the pages of *Life* magazine / So when she arrived at Yale Law School, / She was already a bit of a star.

(1) All was going exceedingly well for young Hillary / Until one night:

(Hillary, with her hair pulled back and wearing thick glasses, sits reading and taking notes on a legal pad. Aphrodite enters.)

APHRODITE: Behold Aphrodite, goddess of love and beauty!

HILLARY: *(Looking up only briefly.)* I don't have time. *(Aphrodite is shocked. She's never received such a greeting.)*

APHRODITE: Perhaps you didn't hear me. I said- Behold

HILLARY: Sssshhhh! This is a library. I don't know how information is disseminated in Olympus, but I've devoted myself to Athena. Alone.

APHRODITE: *(Excited.)* Do you realize that, with a small makeover and a few lessons in the social graces, I could get you any man on this campus?

HILLARY: That is so sexist. It's the 1970s, Aphrodite. Get over yourself.

APHRODITE: How dare you! *(Hillary shakes her head as she puts her glasses back on.)* No woman defies the call of Aphrodite!

HILLARY: News flash: I'm not interested in being a *wife,* I'm interested in being a *leader.*

APHRODITE: You'll regret this. *(Hillary rolls her eyes.)*

CHORUS: (1) And so Hillary had made her first political mistake.

(2) For Athena was not the only goddess / Who had been grooming mortals in her own image. /Aphrodite had her own disciple . . . *(Aphrodite sticks an arrow in Hillary's back.)*

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HILLARY: Ow! *(Hillary pulls the arrow out of her back and looks at it quizzically, then looks up and sees Bill. She is immediately lovestruck.)* Who's *that?*

CHORUS: (2) William Jefferson Clinton. / Bill and Hillary started studying together.

And then things got even hotter:

HILLARY: Bill, the exam is tomorrow.

BILL: Like you even need to study. You're smarter than every other student here. And when you smile, you're just about the most beautiful thing I ever seen.

CHORUS: (1) No one had ever called Hillary beautiful before.

(2) Attractive, yes. Pretty, sometimes. Sturdy, sure. But beautiful? No.

HILLARY: *(Flirtatiously.)* You're a bad influence on me, Bill Clinton.

ATHENA: Aphrodite. You need to stop the games with Hillary. Now. She has important things to accomplish. I don't appreciate you wasting her time with this ridiculous romance.

******* Time passes *********

HILLARY: Working on the Watergate Committee was so exciting! The corruption in that administration is just - *(She shakes her head.)*

ATHENA: Obviously there was obstruction of justice. But how did you argue impeachment?

HILLARY: I argued for a broader definition of the legal justifications for impeachment. This is going to affect presidents for years to come!

ATHENA: You're on exactly the right track, Hillary. Now we need to talk about the next step.

HILLARY: I'm moving. Bill is running for congress in Arkansas this year. After that, he'll run for governor. He'll be the youngest governor in that state ever.

ATHENA: Which would make you the *girlfriend* of the youngest governor in Arkansas ever. Is that why you went to Wellesley? Is that why you went to Yale? Most people don't even know where Arkansas IS!

HILLARY: I'm going to marry Bill Clinton. *(Athena is upset by this news, but gathers herself together.)*

ATHENA: Hillary! Don't you see what's happening? This is the work of Aphrodite. She's using love

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to distract you from your real work.

HILLARY: Why can't I have both, just like men do? Isn't that what you and I are fighting for? I don't want to just be a high-powered attorney working hundred-hour weeks. I want someone to come home to. I want Bill to come home to.

ATHENA: I like Bill. He's a nice boy, but -

HILLARY: He's not just a nice boy. He's going to be president of the United States. *(Athena is shocked.)*

ATHENA: When you first came to me, *you* wanted to be president.

HILLARY: It's not the time, and you and I both know it. There's only one way I'm making it to the White House here and now, and that's on the arm of a man. But Bill *is* the *right* man. He doesn't want a first lady who just smiles at her husband's side. Bill and I will be the first president and first lady who are equals. We'll be two for the price of one. *(Realizes.)* That could be a good campaign slogan.

ATHENA: There's something you should know. About Bill.

HILLARY: *(Quickly.)* I know everything I need to know. With him, I don't have to pretend I don't have ideas and ambitions. He could've picked any number of non-threatening, yes-dear, it-takes-me-an-hour-to-put-on-my-eyelashes types from Arkansas. But he didn't. He chose ME. *(With wonder.)* He loves me.

CHORUS: (2) Hillary's time in Arkansas / Stretched out into eighteen long years. / As Bill was elected governor four times / And she stood behind him for speech after speech / Smiling, nodding, waving, smiling, / All the while preparing themselves / For an election only they believed they could win:

(1 and 2) The presidential campaign of 1992.

(1) But just as it looked like they might have a real chance, / Aphrodite decided it was time to remind Hillary who was *really* in charge ... *(Aphrodite, wearing a wig of big blonde hair, stands behind a microphone, at a press conference.)*

APHRODITE*: (With strong Southern accent.)* My name is Gennifer Flowers, and presidential candidate Bill Clinton and I have had an affair. *(Hillary watches Aphrodite in horror.)*

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We have made sweet sweet love in my bedroom, in my foyer, on my kitchen table, in my pantry

HILLARY: It's lies! Republican lies! *(to Athena)* I can't bear listening to that woman. I can't worry that every time my husband leaves the house, he is - there must be some way you can help me! *(Pause.)*

ATHENA: I didn't want to do this. And yet, maybe it is still what a woman needs to do to succeed in this world. I can remove half your heart. In its place will be anger. An anger all heroes have felt, and it will serve as fuel for your journey. But it has other effects as well.

HILLARY: Such as?

ATHENA: Your ability to compromise . . . The classic female arts that give you social graces, the right tone of voice, the ability to hide a sword behind a smile, those things Lady Bird and Jackie were so very good at, these are strengths you will no longer have. You'll be a warrior. *(Athena looks at Hillary. Hillary nods her assent.)*

CHORUS: (1) And so that night the ravens came. / Their beaks sharpened by all the cruelty in the world.

(2) Their cold, taloned feet perched on Hillary's chest / As they fought each other towards the prize: Half of her embattled heart.

HILLARY: *(Colder and harsher than we've seen her before.)* You know, I'm not sitting here - some little woman standing by my man like Tammy Wynette. I'm sitting here because I love him - and I respect him. And you know, if that's not enough for people, then heck, don't vote for him.

CHORUS: (2) And so it was with Great sacrifices / And a little celestial help - A *lot* of celestial help / Bill and Hillary made it to the White House at last. / Which is when Hillary's problems *really* began.

HILLARY: *(Stiff)* Right now, thirty-seven million Americans do not have health-care. My plan will establish corporate "regional alliances" of health providers. My plan will ensure that, for the first time, women's health-care gets the same attention as men's. My plan -

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CHORUS: (2) Her thirteen-hundred-page health-care plan died an ugly death on the floor of Congress.

HILLARY: Scum-sucking misogynist money-grubbing REPUBLICANS! I'm trying to stop people from DYING!

ATHENA: We misread our enemy. Politics isn't like the battlefield. You have to fight your enemy with one hand and stroke him with the other. *(She pulls out a mass of computerized data.)* According to my polls, right now, they describe you as: strong, intelligent -

HILLARY: *(Pleased.)* Really?

ATHENA: . . . dishonest and a bitch. *(A dead raven with a rolled-up paper in its claws; it lands heavily at Hillary's feet.)* A dead raven.

HILLARY: That doesn't seem like a good sign.

ATHENA: Traditionally ... no. *(Athena reaches over, picks up the bird, and pulls out the paper from its claws. She reads its contents.)*

HILLARY: What is it?

ATHENA: It's a front-page story about the president and a ... young lady.

HILLARY: What?! *(scene change – Hillary confronts Bill)* Tell me it's a lie. *(No response from Bill.)* This girl is only a few years older than Chelsea. *(In a cold, attorney-like tone.)* Who is she? Do you know her?

BILL: Of course. She's an intern at the White House. And a - a troubled young lady . . I swear. I did not have sexual relations with . . . that woman.

HILLARY: *(Giddy with relief)* Of course you didn't! What kind of idiot would believe you would take these kinds of risks when the Republicans are just WAITING for something to bring you down? Who would believe *any* man would throw away his family, his career, his country for - a moment of sleazy pleasure. That's exactly what I'm going to tell the press. *(Lights down on them, then up on . . . Hillary sitting stiffly in a chair. A Newscaster, sits next to her.)*

NEWSCASTER: *(To Hillary.)* The president has described to the American people what this relationship with Monica Lewinsky was *not.* Can you tell the audience watching today:

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What *was* it?

HILLARY: An intense political agenda at work! The true story is this vast right-wing conspiracy that has been conspiring against my husband since the day he announced for president.

NEWSCASTER: Let me take your husband out of this for a second . . . if an American president had an adulterous liaison in the White House and lied to cover it up, should the American people ask for his resignation?

HILLARY: Yes. That would be a very serious offense. In fact, what I implore the Congress to do - is appoint a special prosecutor to look into this. Let them unturn every rock, read every letter my husband has sent, ask every oracle! And if I am wrong, may I be struck down by the gods! *(A thunderbolt. Hillary and the Newscaster start in surprise.)*

CHORUS: (2) It was the first grand jury subpoena for a sitting president's testimony in U.S. history. The country was lit up from coast to coast by the sickly blue of television screens / As people waited to hear the truth. *(Hillary stands alone.)*

HILLARY: *(To herself.)* I will not cry. I will not show humiliation. I will be as strong as a man. I will be a block of marble. *(Hillary goes to Bill.)* Remember, only answer what they ask you. They're going to try and trip you up. If they can create even the appearance of perjury, it could cost us the presidency. Just keep it brief and stick to the truth and you'll be fine.

BILL: *(to the cameras)* It depends on what the meaning of the word "is" is. Now, if someone had asked me on that day, are you having any kind of sexual relations with Ms. Lewinsky, that is, asked me a question in the present tense, I would have said no. And it would have been completely true.

CHORUS: (1) Everyone in the country- and the world - Was buzzing with word of Hillary's humiliation.

HILLARY: Fear is stupid, and I am strong. Fear is stupid and I am strong. Goddamn you, Bill. I will not cry.

CHORUS: (2) One single tear. Fell to the ground / And was quickly drunk by the thirsty earth.

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*******Time passes *******

CHORUS: (2) New York's next senator: Hillary Rodham Clinton! *(The sound of raucous applause, hooting and howling. Hillary is loving it.)*

HILLARY: Thank you all so much. This is amazing, thank you. There are people who said I couldn't do this, but they weren't counting on you. *(Raucous applause.)*

CHORUS: (2) Back in that spot / In the White House Rose Garden / Where Hillary's tear had fallen / Something happened to the flowers. / Their beauty grew sharper / And so did their thorns / Put there to protect their splendor / From an often unwelcoming world. / If you stand in the Rose Garden, even today, / And listen very closely, / You can still hear the faintest sound / Of a woman's voice:

HILLARY: **. . .** There was a time when a woman's dream of being a senator would have been called impossible. The year I was born, 1947, there were no women in the senate. But now I'm here. And I do believe that, one day, whether it be my generation or the next, we will have a female president.

CLOSING

ACTRESS 2: *And we all know how that turned out!*
ACTRESS 1: *Close . . . but no cigar!!*
ACTRESS 1: *Michelle Obama for PRESIDENT!*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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